

Is the scope for employment then a basic criteria?

"Yes, and that is why we encourage industries dealing in textile, gems and jewellery, apparels, leather products. All these are employment intensive areas."

How much foreign investment is coming into West Bengal now?

"We are trying for that. To be honest the amount of foreign investment is not as much as we would like it to be. But we have proposals from Germany and Japan."

How does the state government look to go beyond and rise above the controversies regarding land acquisition for industrial growth?

"We have a rehab policy in place. West Bengal has mostly fertile land and there is very little fallow area to be used for industrial purposes. We have already marked out those areas and the plan in future is to avoid fertile and homestead land. We are trying to look for more land in the traditional industrial belt in Kolkata, Howrah and its surroundings, in Durgapur, Haldia, Bankura and Birbhum. Even areas in Kharagpur and Jhargram can be used as they are not really fertile. But what is important is that we have a plans for proper rehabilitation and compensation for those whose land has been taken. Even bargadars have been compensated. We are also discussing how to help agricultural labourers who don't own the land, but work on them. Moreover, with land value increasing with industrialisation, we will try to draw up a compensation package accordingly."

What else will make industrialisation seem more attractive to the local population?

"We are doing a survey in the industrial zones looking into the socio-economic reality of the area. Depending on that survey, community development will be done. There will be facilities for healthcare and education. The overall quality of life will improve."

**HIGH POINT FOR IT-SECTOR
India Design Centre**



For the IT industry things are only getting better in West Bengal. Soon the state will have a 18-floor India Design Centre, the first of its kind venture in India.

Chip giants such as Intel, Texas Instruments, Qualcomm, Cadence, Synopsis and Sequence have been invited by the West Bengal Government to work at the Centre.

A chip comes out through the design and fabrication process. India is emerging as a hub for chip design, while fabrication work is done elsewhere and involves huge investment. The country could move up the value chain and become a chip fabrication hub in the future.

The facility, conforming to international standards, is being set up by Webel at the Salt Lake Electronics Complex. Webel will provide the land, a 1.7-acre plot in Sector V, the city's IT hub. The IDC will be built in the PPP model. A private partner will invest in the infrastructure.

The 100,000 sq. ft. facility will cover the entire semiconductor spectrum – VLSI design, assembling, testing and packaging and would be operational by mid 2009.

INCREDIBLE BENGAL

West Bengal is a state that is blessed with natural beauty, heritage and history. And so it is just a natural extension that tourism can be developed in this state in a big way and the state government is trying to tap the bounty of nature to make the state more attractive to tourists. From the Himalayan range in North Bengal to the mangrove forests at the Sunderbans, West Bengal has it all. Hills, beaches, forests, heritage sites, historical places – there is no dearth of attraction in this state.

West Bengal can boast of World Heritage sites like the Sunderbans and the Toy Train in Darjeeling. The hills of North Bengal, the tea gardens, the historical sites at Bishnupur and Murshidabad, the beaches of Digha and Sankarpur – all have their inherent charm and draw tourists in large numbers. The West Bengal government has tourist department hotels in all these areas and is ready to help private enterprise that will develop tourism and hospitality industry in the state.

West Bengal is a state where the development of agriculture and industry has been simultaneous. The government has for long made efforts to uplift the living conditions of the rural population and land reforms had played a major role. Later, the concept of Shilpabandhu, the resourceful single window agency, set up in 1984 by WBIDC and reconstituted in 1994, came as a boon for industrial players.



It extends assistance to entrepreneurs in setting up medium and large-scale industries and co-ordinates the functions of different departments to procure the necessary clearances and inputs for them.

With new industries and petro-chemical hubs being planned and a robust IT industry making its presence felt in the state, West Bengal is again on the threshold of becoming a strong industrial base of the country with new and attractive career opportunities for the youth.

